this country and of the numerous and complicated difficulties I have had to contend with . . . I cannot do more than I have done.' He went on to outline the trouble he was having managing the increasingly distraught Shuja. 'Of late I have had several most distressing interviews with His Majesty, and I may safely say that the efforts I have been making towards the reduction of the public expenditure have not only been the cause of much mental distress to His Majesty, but have secured for us the hostility of all the men of influence in the country.' In the end, however, Macnaghten as the good civil servant realised he must bow to the inevitable. 'Your Lordship's perpetual exhortations left me no alternative but to counsel unsparing retrenchment. The enormous expenditure already incurred I am aware necessitates the strictest economy. But what can be done with a Kingdom whose net revenues are only fifteen Lakhs [1,500,000] of Rupees per annum?'[50]

Macnaghten decided to leave Shuja's already reduced household budget more or less intact and not to touch the expenditure committed to the new, reformed regiments of the Shah's Afghan national army. Instead he chose to aim the cuts at the extremities rather than the centre. He called the Ghilzai and Khyber chieftains to a durbar in Kabul. There he told them that their subsidies were to be reduced by £8,000, with the worst reductions falling on the eastern Ghilzais and their leader Mohammad Shah Khan, the father-in-law of Akbar Khan, who had been awarded the daunting title of 'Chief Executioner' when he came over and joined the service of Shah Shuja. To Macnaghten it made perfect sense: he believed that the days of the old nobility, as in India, were numbered. He was merely hastening the inevitable demise of the feudal system and calling the bluff of the more barbaric nomad tribes who had done little to deserve the protection money the Kabul government was in the habit of lavishing upon them.

In the event, however, it proved to be the single biggest misjudgement of his entire career and within weeks it had brought the entire edifice of the occupation crashing down. For as far as the Ghilzais were concerned, they had worked hard for their subsidy and believed they were being called to Kabul to be rewarded for their support of the Shah's regime. 'They had prevented even a finger from being raised against our posts, couriers and weak detachments,' wrote Henry Havelock. 'Convoys of all descriptions had passed through these terrific defiles, the strongest mountain barriers in the world, with little or no interruption from these predatory tribes. The transmission of letters to our own provinces was as regular as between